

DESIGN REFERENCE

How to Design a Template

A short checklist to follow before starting any new template — so the design can be automatically filled for any type of business, with great-looking results every time.

For designers — no technical background needed

This is a checklist for designing templates that our system can fill automatically for **any business** — a restaurant, a gym, a salon, a festival post, anything — using the same template. Follow these rules and the AI-generated result will look clean and professional. Skip them and the template will only really work for one type of business, or the text may not fit, or colours may clash.

1 Keep decorations as shapes, not images

RULE Anything decorative (borders, patterns, dividers, blobs, stripes, circles, sparkles) should be a **shape**, not a flattened picture or icon.

WHY Shapes automatically change colour when a user picks their own colour theme. Images never do — an image stays exactly as you drew it, forever.

✓ **DO**

A circle, blob, wave, stripe, gradient panel, dotted line, starburst, simple geometric borders and frames.

✗ **DON'T**

A picture of a fork and knife, a dumbbell, a flower — anything that clearly represents a real object from one specific industry.

Simple test: Look at the decoration alone, with no text or photo around it. If you can say "that's clearly a restaurant thing" or "that's clearly a gym thing" — it's not generic enough, and it will look wrong when the same template is used for a different business.

✓ Good: a soft gold circle behind the headline. ✗ Bad: a picture of a pizza slice behind the headline.

2 Use real text boxes, not text baked into an image

RULE Every headline, subheading, body line, phone number, address, etc. must be an actual **editable text layer** — never text that's part of a flattened image or graphic.

WHY Our system rewrites every text box automatically to match whatever the user asks for. If text is baked into an image, it can never be changed — the design stays stuck with your placeholder words forever.

✓ **DO**

Type "Call us today: 000-0000" as a real text box.

✗ **DON'T**

Design that line in Photoshop/Illustrator and export it as one flat picture.

3 Only use real images for actual photos

RULE Images/photos should only be used for things that are genuinely a photo — a background scene, a product shot, a food photo, a person. Everything else (decoration, borders, icons) should be shapes (see Rule 1).

WHY Photo slots get replaced automatically with a brand-new AI-generated photo that matches the user's actual business — as long as the slot is clearly just a photo placeholder and not mixed together with logos or decorations in the same image.

Also important:

- Keep the background photo, any product/subject photo, and the logo as **3 separate layers**. Never merge them into a single flattened image.
- Don't design a background photo where important decorations or text are painted directly into the photo itself — if the photo gets replaced, that decoration/text disappears with it.

4 Keep the logo separate and simple

RULE The logo should be its own single layer, clearly a logo (not mixed with other graphics), placed somewhere sensible (corner, header, footer).

WHY The logo is the one thing that's never regenerated — it gets swapped for the business's real logo, exactly as-is, with no cropping or recolouring. If it's tangled up with other design elements, swapping it will break the layout.

5 Leave breathing room for text of different lengths

RULE Don't design a text box that only works for your exact placeholder words. Assume the real text could be shorter or up to ~30–40% longer.

WHY A user's actual headline or offer text is rarely the same length as your placeholder. If the box is too tight, text will get cut off or shrink to be unreadable.

- Leave extra vertical/horizontal space around text boxes.
- Test your layout by typing a noticeably longer sentence into each text box and make sure it still looks fine (or at least doesn't break the layout).

6 Keep the colour palette small and simple

RULE Use at most 3–4 main colours in a template (plus black/white/neutral greys as needed).

WHY When a user picks their own colour palette, our system maps your template's colours onto theirs, one by one, by how prominent each colour is. Too many random colours crammed in makes this mapping messy and the result muddy.

Also: make sure text has strong contrast against whatever is behind it (a light colour on a light background, or dark on dark, will fail readability checks and get force-changed automatically — better to design it readable from the start).

7 Keep text and photos on separate layers from their background

RULE Never assume a text box will always sit on the exact same coloured shape or exact same part of a photo — but do design it so it clearly sits *on* a specific shape (for automatic contrast-matching) or clearly *on* the open picture area (not on a busy, detailed part of the photo).

WHY Our system checks contrast against whatever is directly behind each text box. If text sits on a plain shape, that's easy to check and fix. If it sits over a very busy, detailed part of a photo, contrast is harder to guarantee.

✓ DO

Place important text over a plain sky, a soft blurred area, a solid-colour panel, or a shape with a flat fill.

✗ DON'T

Place important text directly over small, highly-detailed objects in a photo (e.g. right on top of a person's face or tiny cluttered objects).

8 Don't hardcode business-specific words into "fixed" labels

RULE Even short labels/buttons ("Order Now", "Book a Table", "Shop Now") should be normal, editable text boxes — not locked, not baked into a graphic.

WHY These get rewritten too ("Book Now" → "Join a Class", etc., depending on the business). If they're locked or flattened into an image, the wrong wording will stay stuck on designs for completely unrelated businesses.

Quick checklist before you submit a template

- ☐ All decorations are shapes (no icons/graphics that scream one specific industry)
- ☐ All text is real, editable text boxes — nothing baked into an image
- ☐ Background photo, subject/product photo, and logo are 3 separate layers
- ☐ Logo is clean, isolated, not mixed with other graphics
- ☐ Text boxes have extra room for longer/shorter text
- ☐ No more than ~3–4 main colours used
- ☐ Text has clear contrast against whatever sits behind it
- ☐ Important text isn't sitting on a busy/cluttered part of a photo
- ☐ No label/button text is locked or flattened into a graphic

If every box above is checked, the template will work well for many different businesses, not just the one you had in mind while designing it.